

Cybersecurity for SME Employees

Module 3.1 – What is Social Engineering?

1 Objective

Help employees understand how cyber attackers manipulate human behavior to gain access to systems, data, or money.

2 Introduction

Not all cyber attacks are technical. Many start by tricking people into doing something risky—like clicking a link, sharing a password, or approving a fake payment. This manipulation is known as **social engineering**. Attackers rely on psychology, not just software, to breach companies.

3 Definition of Social Engineering

- Social engineering is the use of deception to manipulate individuals into giving up confidential or personal information.
- Often used to bypass technical security systems by targeting human behavior.
- Commonly the first stage of a larger cyberattack (e.g., phishing to get access credentials).

4 Why It Works

- People are trusting and helpful by nature.
- Attackers create urgency to force fast decisions.
- Employees may not always verify identities or requests.
- Fear, curiosity, and authority are powerful motivators.

5 Psychological Triggers Used in Attacks

- **Urgency:** "Act now or face consequences!"
- **Authority:** "This is your CEO—transfer the money now."
- **Scarcity:** "Only 2 hours left to claim your prize."

- **Greed:** "You've won a reward—click to collect."
- **Fear:** "Your account has been compromised."
- **Trust:** Pretending to be a coworker or vendor.

6 Types of Social Engineering

- **Phishing:** Emails pretending to be legitimate.
- **Vishing:** Phone calls claiming to be from tech support, banks, etc.
- **Smishing:** SMS messages asking you to click or reply.
- **Impersonation:** Pretending to be someone the target knows.
- **Baiting:** Leaving infected USBs labeled "Confidential" in public areas.
- **Pretexting:** Creating a fabricated scenario to get info.

7 Example Scenario

A person calls claiming to be from IT support. They say there's an urgent issue with your device and ask you to install remote access software. You feel pressured and comply. Later, company systems are compromised. The attacker used authority and urgency—classic social engineering tactics.

8 How to Protect Yourself

- Always verify identities before taking action.
- Be cautious of unexpected emails, calls, or requests.
- Slow down—don't let urgency cloud your judgment.
- Report suspicious interactions to IT or security.
- Trust your instincts—if something feels off, it probably is.

9 Conclusion

Social engineering preys on human behavior, not just computer flaws. Being aware of these tricks is the first step in stopping them. In the next session, we'll look at one of the most common types of social engineering: phishing.